User Documentation – StampCatalogue

Stamp collection management and tracking application

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Technologies: Python 3, PyQt6, SQLite / MS Access, openpyxl

1. General Overview

StampCatalogue is a standalone desktop application developed in Python and PyQt6. It is designed to help philatelists easily manage the ownership status of their stamps, browse catalogues by country, and automatically generate mancolists (wishlists).

The application is part of the **PhilaOffice** suite and shares the same automatic image resolution logic (via the `getPhotoName` function) as well as a unified internationalization system with *StampAlbum*.

2. Architecture and Data Structure

The application is built on a clear separation between user collection management and read-only philatelic catalogue browsing:

2.1. Central User Database (`collections.db`)

Stored in the `Databases/` folder, this SQLite database manages user-specific items:

- **`collections`**: List of created collections (Name, associated Country, creation date).
- **`collection_items`**: List of stamps saved in each collection (Stamp number, status, condition, quantity, purchase price, notes).

2.2. Country Catalogue Databases (`<CountryName>.db`)

SQLite files located in the `Databases/` directory (read-only mode). Each database contains the `Stamp_List` table listing the stamps (number `nbr`, year `year`, type `type`, value/color `valuecolor`, description `stampDescription`, sub-number `sub_nbr`, etc.).

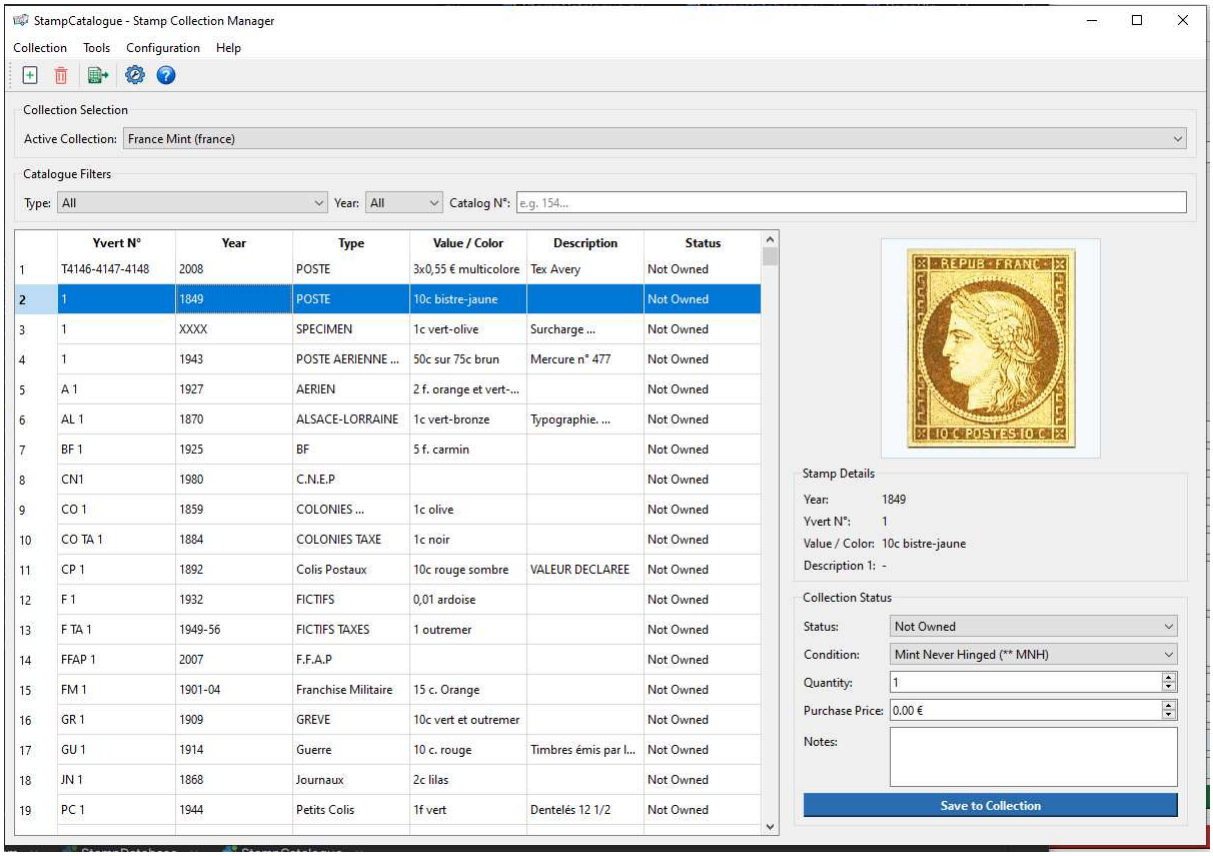
2.3. Images and Photos Directory

Stamp visuals are dynamically retrieved from the `Images/` and `Photos/` folders. The `getPhotoName` function generates image file names using standard prefixes (e.g., `A` for Airmail => `T01-030-...`, `BF` for Souvenir Sheet => `T01-080-...`, `S` for Official Stamp => `T01-170-...`).

3. Getting Started and User Interface

The main interface consists of four major interactive areas:

```
+-------------------------------------------------------------------------+
| Menu Bar: Collection | Tools | Configuration | Help                     |
| Toolbar: [New] [Delete] | [Export] | [Config] [Manual]                  |
+-------------------------------------------------------------------------+
| Active Collection Selector (Dropdown)                                   |
+-------------------------------------------------------------------------+
| Catalogue Filters: Type [All] | Year [All] | Catalog N° [    ]          |
+-----------------------------------+-------------------------------------+
| STAMP TABLE                       | RIGHT PANEL                         |
| (Yvert N°, Year, Type, Value,     | - Image Preview Area (200px)        |
|  Description, Status)             | - Detailed Stamp File               |
|                                   | - Status Management Form            |
+-----------------------------------+-------------------------------------+
```



3.1. Menu Bar and Toolbar

Provides quick access to essential features:

- **Collection**: Create a new collection (`Ctrl+N`), delete the current collection, Quit (`Ctrl+Q`).
- **Tools**: Export the mancolist to Excel format.

- **Configuration**: Settings dialog box.
- **Help**: User manual (dynamic opening of the PDF based on language) and "About" dialog box.

4. Feature Guide

4.1. Creating and Managing a Collection

1. Click **Collection -> New Collection...** or use the toolbar icon.
2. Enter an explicit name (e.g., *France Mint 1900-1950*) and select the corresponding country from the drop-down list populated from the `Databases/` folder.
3. Click **OK**. The collection is automatically selected, and the country catalogue is loaded.

4.2. Navigating and Filtering the Catalogue

To quickly locate a stamp in the grid:

- **Filter by Type**: Select a specific category (e.g., *Airmail*, *Souvenir Sheets*, *Postage Due*) or *All*.
- **Filter by Year**: Filter stamps by issue year.
- **Search by Catalogue N°**: Enter all or part of the number in the *Catalog N°* field.
- **Sorting**: Click column headers in the table to sort by number, year, or description.

4.3. Entering Ownership Status

When a stamp is selected in the table:

1. The stamp image appears in the top-right panel if the photo file exists.
2. In the **Collection Status** form, fill in:
    - **Status**: *Owned* (green), *Manco / Wanted* (red), *Ordered*, or *Not Owned*.
    - **Condition**: *Mint Never Hinged (** MNH*), Mint Hinged (MH)*, *Used (Cancelled)*, *On Cover*.
    - **Quantity** and **Purchase Price**.
    - **Personal Notes**.
3. Click **Save to Collection**. The table immediately updates the color and text in the *Status* column.

4.4. Exporting a Mancolist to Excel

1. Select the collection from which you want to extract missing stamps.
2. Click **Tools -> Export Mancolist (Excel)** or the dedicated icon.
3. The application identifies all stamps marked as *Manco (Wanted)* or *Not Owned*.
4. Choose the save location for the `.xlsx` file.
5. The generated file includes a styled header and automatic column width adjustment.

5. Configuration and Customization

Access the dialog box via **Configuration -> Settings...**:

- **Interface Language**: Choice between *Français* (`fr`) and *English* (`en`). The interface adjusts menus and text in the "About" module accordingly.
- **Database Engine**: Support for *SQLite* (`.db`) or *Microsoft Access* (`.mdb`) engines.

Settings are saved in the `StampCatalogue.cfg` configuration file in UTF-8 INI format.